

Usability study

A research method that assesses how easy it is for participants to complete core tasks in a design

Unmoderated usability study

Participants test out the prototypes without human guidance

Moderated usability study

A moderator guides participants through the study in real time

	Benefits	Limitations
Moderated usability studies	• Guide the participant through the study • Ask specific questions and follow up in real time • Rapport building between the moderator and participant	• Moderator could influence or bias the participants • Less flexible • Participant may not identify with the moderator
Unmoderated usability studies	• Participant uses the product in the real world • Participant completes tasks on their own time and in their own space • Participant may feel more comfortable giving feedback without others around	• No human guidance if issues arise • No real-time follow up questions • Little to no control over the environment

Unmoderated usability study



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Moderated usability study

How to begin a moderated usability study

1. Build a rapport with participants
2. Thank participants for coming
3. Remind participants to be open and honest
4. Have participants fill out paperwork, like an NDA
5. Explain the focus of the study and what participants will give feedback on
6. Establish ground rules for the study
7. Remind participants that they are not being tested
8. Keep your emotions neutral

Techniques for moderating a usability study

- Ask open-ended questions
- Ask follow up questions
- Summarize their answer for confirmation

Bias

Favoring or having prejudice against something based on limited information

Implicit bias

The collection of attitudes and stereotypes we associate to people without our conscious knowledge

Serial position effect

When given a list of items, people are more likely to remember the first few and the last few, while the items in the middle tend to blur

Friendliness bias

The tendency of people to agree with those they like in order to maintain a non-confrontational conversation

Social desirability bias

The tendency for people to answer questions in a way that will be viewed favorably by others

How to reduce bias when conducting usability studies

- Identify and admit your own biases
- Find participants from a representative sample
- Define the research criteria beforehand
- Phrase interview questions thoughtfully
- Let participants express themselves fully and in their own words
- Be mindful of your body language

Why take notes during a usability study?

1. Capture any thoughts you have during the usability study
2. Summarize a participant's experience during the study
3. Highlight compelling quotes to include in your research report

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1		Participant A	Participant B	Participant C	Participant D	Participant E	
2	Observation						
3	Observation						
4	Observation						
5	Observation						
6	Observation						
7	Observation						
8	Observation						
9	Observation						
10	Observation						
11	Observation						
12	Observation						
13	Observation						
14	Observation						
15	Observation						
16	Observation						
17	Observation						
18	Observation						
19	Observation						
20	Observation						
21	Observation						
22	Observation						
23							

	Participant A	Participant B	Participant C	Participant D	Participant E
Selects a date and time to schedule a dog walker					
Confused by how to select a date and time to schedule a dog walker					
Chooses a dog walker from the list					
Trouble choosing a dog walker from the list					
Completes the checkout process					
Issues completing the checkout process					
Can find page to edit address					
Difficulty finding page to edit address					
Thinks dog walking app is useful					
Does not think dog walking app is useful					
Speaks in a positive tone					
Speaks in an indifferent tone					
Speaks in a frustrated tone					
Speaks in an annoyed tone					
Speaks in a confident tone					
Wants to be able to book dog walker repeatedly					
Surprised there's no confirmation page before completing checkout					
Prefers a calendar to select a date, instead of a box to type a date					
Wishes they could filter dog walkers by experience level					
Observation					
Observation					
Observation					

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Quote from Participant B

“I’m going to assume if this was clickable, I’d see a calendar at this point. Ok, done.”

Quote from Participant B

“I don’t really know if dog walkers near you is how to schedule or if this ‘Schedule a walk’ thing is the way to go. I’m a bit confused.”

Quote from Participant B

“Any of these work for me, so I’m just going to click one of these rectangles that say ‘Learn more’.”

Quote from Participant B

“Oh, that was super easy. Looks like I’m all set on that one.”

Quote from Participant B

“Cool, so it’s probably here under the logo for a person. Great. Found it.”

Quote from Participant B

“I don’t know if it’s that useful, especially since you can’t book a recurring time.”

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